

EARLY INDUSTRIAL WARFARE

THE BATTLE OF ANTIETAM

Antietam displayed the weaponry and tactics of the American Civil War at their most deadly. Fought at Sharpsburg, Maryland, on 17 September 1862, it was the costliest day's fighting in American history, with 22,700 Union and Confederate soldiers killed or wounded.

At Sharpsburg a Union army about 75,000 strong, commanded by General George B. McClellan, faced a much weaker Confederate army led by General Robert E. Lee. The Confederates had taken up a defensive position behind Antietam Creek, where they did not dig earthworks but made optimal use of features such as woods, hills, and fences. Lee was still assembling scattered forces when the battle began, but eventually 38,000 Confederate troops would take part.

After a hard marching campaign in Maryland, the Confederates were in poor shape – a Union officer described the troops as “filthy, sick, hungry, and miserable”. The Union troops, on the other hand, had been well equipped and supplied by Northern factories.

On the day before the battle began McClellan sent troops across Antietam Creek to General Lee's left. The Confederates observed the movement, and soldiers under General Thomas “Stonewall” Jackson got into position to face a flank attack at dawn on 17 September.

The battle opened with an exchange of cannon fire from the batteries that each side had established on high ground. Union troops then marched onward to a cornfield where Jackson's infantry awaited them. After bringing forward their cannon, the Union divisions swept the cornfield with canister shot – anti-personnel munitions that decimated the Confederates. The Union troops pressed forward and hours of desperate infantry fighting ensued. Men exchanged fire in the open, inflicting and sustaining heavy losses. Groups of men were marshalled by their

officers in attacks and counterattacks, especially around and through an area known as West Wood. Soldiers were armed with rifled muskets – muzzle-loaded weapons capable of three or four shots a minute – although in places men fought at close quarters with bayonets or wielded their muskets as clubs. Combat on the left flank eventually subsided due to shock and exhaustion on both sides.

FIRING FROM COVER

Meanwhile, elsewhere on the battlefield, the Confederates, using their muskets, were demonstrating the effectiveness of infantry when firing from cover against troops advancing in the open. In the centre, some 2,500 men held a sunken road – later known as Bloody Lane – against repeated frontal assaults, inflicting thousands of casualties before being overrun.

Further to the Confederate right, Union General Ambrose Burnside tried to move troops over the Creek across a bridge, under the fire of Confederate sharpshooters and cannon. Time and again the Union soldiers were cut down, and only established themselves on the other side of the Creek after bringing up their own artillery in support.

By late afternoon the Confederates had been outflanked on the right and looked about to be beaten, when Confederate reinforcements marching from Harpers Ferry arrived and counterattacked, causing Union troops to retreat. The cautious McClellan had held 20,000 infantry and cavalry in reserve throughout. He made no attempt to resume fighting the next day, and Lee withdrew his battered army to Virginia.

